

To do and for doing

Learner workbook

Explain a purpose or the function of an object.

Understand the distinction

Use to + base verb to explain an action's purpose: I went out to buy bread. Use for + noun for a purpose or recipient: a bag for groceries; a gift for Lee.

For + -ing often describes a function: a tool for opening bottles. A to-infinitive can also describe a use: something to open bottles with. Do not use for buying to explain why you went out in the basic I went out to buy pattern.

Compare the patterns

PURPOSE OF ACTION

I called to ask a question.

To ask gives the reason for calling.

FUNCTION

This brush is for cleaning shoes.

For cleaning describes the use.

RECIPIENT

This message is for Ana.

Ana is the intended recipient.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: I am saving money ___ buy a bike.

A. for

B. to

C. for to

2. Complete: This tool is for ___ cans. (open)

A. opened

B. open

C. opening

3. Choose the correction: I went to the shop for buy milk.

A. I went to the shop to buy milk.

B. I went to the shop to buying milk.

C. I went to the shop for to buy milk.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair correctly gives a purpose for a bottle and the function of a brush?

- A. I bought a bottle to carry water. This small brush is for cleaning it.
- B. I bought a bottle to carry water. This small brush is for to cleaning it.
- C. I bought a bottle for carry water. This small brush is for cleaning it.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. to

Use the infinitive to express the purpose of saving.

2. C. opening

A verb after for takes the -ing form.

3. A. I went to the shop to buy milk.

To buy explains the purpose of the trip.

4. A. I bought a bottle to carry water. This small brush is for cleaning it.

To carry gives the purpose; for cleaning gives the brush's function.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-29.html